Elijah Watson

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I am an anthropologist-demographer studying how historical and contemporary societal shocks shape local population health in social, economic, and evolutionary context.

Research Areas: developmental and fetal origins; natural experiments; social (epi)genomics; longitudinal (birth) cohorts

Appointment

2026– **NIH T32 Postdoctoral Fellow**, Department of Sociology, University of Chicago
NIA Specialized Training Program in the Demography and Economics of Aging
Center for Health and the Social Sciences

Education

2026 **Ph.D.**, Biological Anthropology, Northwestern University
Fellowships: NSF Graduate Research Fellow; NIH F31 Fellow
Certificates: Society, Biology, and Health; Management for PhDs (Kellogg School of Management)

2026 **M.P.H.**, Epidemiology, Northwestern University, Feinberg School of Medicine

2019 **B.A.**, Anthropology, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill
Minor: Medicine, Literature, and Culture
Study abroad: Honors Carolina Semester in Cape Town, South Africa (2017)

Grants

2024–2026 **Ruth L. Kirschstein Predoctoral Individual National Research Service Award (F31)**, National Institute on Aging, F31AG084273 ($88,110) [link]

Publications

Peer-reviewed articles

1. Thomas W. McDade, Sofia Carrera, Calen P. Ryan, **Elijah Watson**, Linda S. Adair, Nanette R. Lee, Delia B. Carba, Julie L. MacIsaac, Kristy Dever, Michael S. Kobor, and Christopher W. Kuzawa. 2026. "Chronic Inflammation and Multiple Dimensions of Aging among Women in the Philippines." *Journals of Gerontology, Series A: Biological Sciences*. [link]
2. **Elijah Watson**, Delaney Glass, and Lucia Petito. 2025. "Toward New Directions in Human Biology: A Roadmap for Anthropological Causal Inference with Observational Data." *American Journal of Human Biology*. [link]
3. Chihua Li, Rebecca Stebbins, Grace Noppert, Constanza Carney, Chunyu Liu, Ashley Sapp, **Elijah Watson**, and Allison Aiello. 2024. "Peripheral Immune Function and Alzheimer's Disease: A Living Systematic Review and Critical Appraisal." *Molecular Psychiatry*. [link]

4. Margaret Butler, Britney Smart, **Elijah Watson**, Shreya Narla, and Lauren Keenan-Devlin. 2023. "Breastfeeding Durations Differ at the Intersection of Race/Ethnicity and Educational Attainment in a Nationally Representative Sample from the US." *Journal of Human Lactation*. [link]
5. Melissa Manus, **Elijah Watson**, Sahana Kuthyar, Delia Carba, Nikola Belarmino, Thomas McDade, Christopher Kuzawa, and Katherine Amato. 2023. "Prenatal Household Size and Composition Are Associated with Infant Fecal Bacterial Diversity in Cebu, Philippines." *American Journal of Biological Anthropology*. [link]
6. Amanda Thompson, Khristopher Nicholas, **Elijah Watson**, Enrique Terán, and Margaret Bentley. 2019. "Water, Food, and the Dual Burden of Disease in Galápagos, Ecuador." *American Journal of Human Biology*. [link]

Submitted

Elijah Watson, Thomas McDade, Lucia Petito, Calen P. Ryan, Nanette Lee, Delia Carba, Julia MacIsaac, Kristy Dever, Michael Kobor, Linda Adair, and Christopher Kuzawa. "An Early-Life Economic Crisis and Urban–Rural Divergence in Epigenetic Aging over Young Adulthood." Submitted to *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*.

Elijah Watson, Thomas McDade, Calen P. Ryan, Nanette Lee, Delia Carba, Julia MacIsaac, Kristy Dever, Michael Kobor, Linda Adair, and Christopher Kuzawa. "A Longitudinal Validation of Epigenetic Clocks among Middle-Aged Filipino Women." Submitted to *Journals of Gerontology, Series A: Medical Sciences*.

Delaney J. Glass, Jeffrey G. Snodgrass, Choeeta Chakrabarti, Kateryna Maltseva, Katya Xinyi Zhao, **Elijah Watson**, François Dengah, and Seth Sagstetter. "Counterfactual Logic Improves Ethnographic Explanation: Bridging Anthropological and Interdisciplinary Perspectives on Causality." Submitted to *Journal of Mixed Methods Research*.

Working papers

"The Tempest, Again: Epigenetic Aging and Recurrent Housing Damage Three Decades after a Childhood Typhoon in Cebu, Philippines."

Presentations

Workshops: Berkeley Formal Demography Workshop (2025); UCLA/USC Workshop on Determinants of Adult Mortality, Morbidity, and Healthy Aging in LMICs (2026)

Conferences

- Population Association of America: 2026
- Advances in Social Genomics Conference, University of Wisconsin–Madison: 2026
- Evolutionary Demography Society, Colorado State University: 2026
- Human Biology Association: 2019, 2022, 2024, 2025
- Interdisciplinary Association of Population Health Scientists: 2022 (Travel Scholarship Recipient), 2025
- Society for Epidemiologic Research: 2022, 2023

Invited lectures: Department of Data and Decision Sciences, Emory University (2026); Montgomery Lecture Series, Center for Medical Humanities and Bioethics, Northwestern University Feinberg School of Medicine (2026)

Other speaking engagements

2025 "Causal Inference with Observational Data." Guest lecture, graduate seminar in biological anthropology, University of Toronto

2024 "EpiCause 2024: Causality in Epidemiology." Institute of Philosophy and Scientific Method, Johannes Kepler University Linz, Austria

2022 "Statistical versus Causal Inference." Panelist, Frontiers in Social Evolution (FINE) Seminar

Teaching

2025– **Instructor of Record**, Northwestern University
Climate Change and Sustainability in Health Care (Winter 2025, Winter 2026)
- Co-designed and co-instructed Northwestern's first medical school elective on climate and sustainability

2022–2023 **Teaching Assistant**, Northwestern University
- Intermediate Epidemiology
- Introduction to Epidemiology
- The Social Determinants of Health
- Introduction to Global Health

2024 **Workshop Instructor**, Northwestern University
R for Social Data Science. Five-session workshop on reproducible data science (R, tidyverse, RStudio, Quarto, GitHub)

Mentorship

2023–2024 Silas Colombara, undergraduate research mentee

Grants, Fellowships, and Awards

Graduate school

2024 **E.E. Hunt, Jr. Award**, Human Biology Association, for an outstanding graduate student oral presentation

2020 **Graduate Research Fellowship**, National Science Foundation ($138,000)

Undergraduate (2019 and earlier)

2019 **Frances L. Phillips Travel Scholarship**, UNC ($9,500)

2019 **Undergraduate Research Consultant Team Grant**, UNC ($10,000). Pilot fieldwork on food and water security on Isabela Island, Galápagos, with Universidad San Francisco de Quito and the UNC Galápagos Science Center

2019 **Honigmann Undergraduate Thesis Award**, UNC Department of Anthropology

2019 **Travel Award**, Center for Communicable Disease Dynamics, Harvard University, Conference to Increase Diversity in Mathematical Modeling and Public Health

2018 **Gillian T. Cell Senior Thesis Research Grant**, UNC

2015 **Johnston Scholar**, UNC–Chapel Hill (merit scholarship with faculty mentoring for high-achieving undergraduates with financial need)

Field Research and Related Experience

2019	**Galápagos Islands, Ecuador.** Field research, San Cristóbal and Isabela Islands (two months)
2019	**South Africa.** Two months across Cape Town, the Western Cape, and Johannesburg to inform my NSF GRFP proposal on food and water insecurity in South Africa (GRFP awarded; dissertation project later changed due to the COVID-19 pandemic). Supported by the Frances L. Phillips Travel Scholarship
2019	**Europe.** Two months in London, Brussels, Amsterdam, Paris, Berlin, Prague, Vienna, and Barcelona, visiting cultural and historical sites, museums, and historic graveyards. Supported by the Frances L. Phillips Travel Scholarship
2018	**Summer Research Program**, Carolina Population Center, UNC–Chapel Hill
2017	**Migrant Employment Access Programme Intern**, Scalabrini Centre of Cape Town, South Africa

Service

2025–2026	Curriculum Committee, Program in Public Health, Northwestern University Feinberg School of Medicine
2023–2025	Student Committee and Webinar Co-Chair, Interdisciplinary Association for Population Health Science
2023–2024	Science Club Mentor, Pedersen-McCormick Boys & Girls Club (Boys & Girls Clubs of Chicago / Northwestern Science in Society Program)

Additional Training

2025	Berkeley Workshop in Formal Demography, University of California, Berkeley
2023	Society for Epidemiologic Research workshops: Causal Inference with Time-Varying Exposures; Introduction to Parametric and Semi-parametric Estimators for Causal Inference; Writing Reproducible Research in R with Quarto
2022	Key Topics in Causal Inference, CAUSALab, Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health
2022	Mixtape Sessions: Causal Inference, taught by Scott Cunningham

Op-Eds and Other Writing

2025	"Climate Studies, National Institutes of Health Under Attack." *Asheville Citizen Times*

Professional Memberships

Population Association of America; Evolutionary Demography Society; Human Biology Association; Interdisciplinary Association of Population Health Scientists